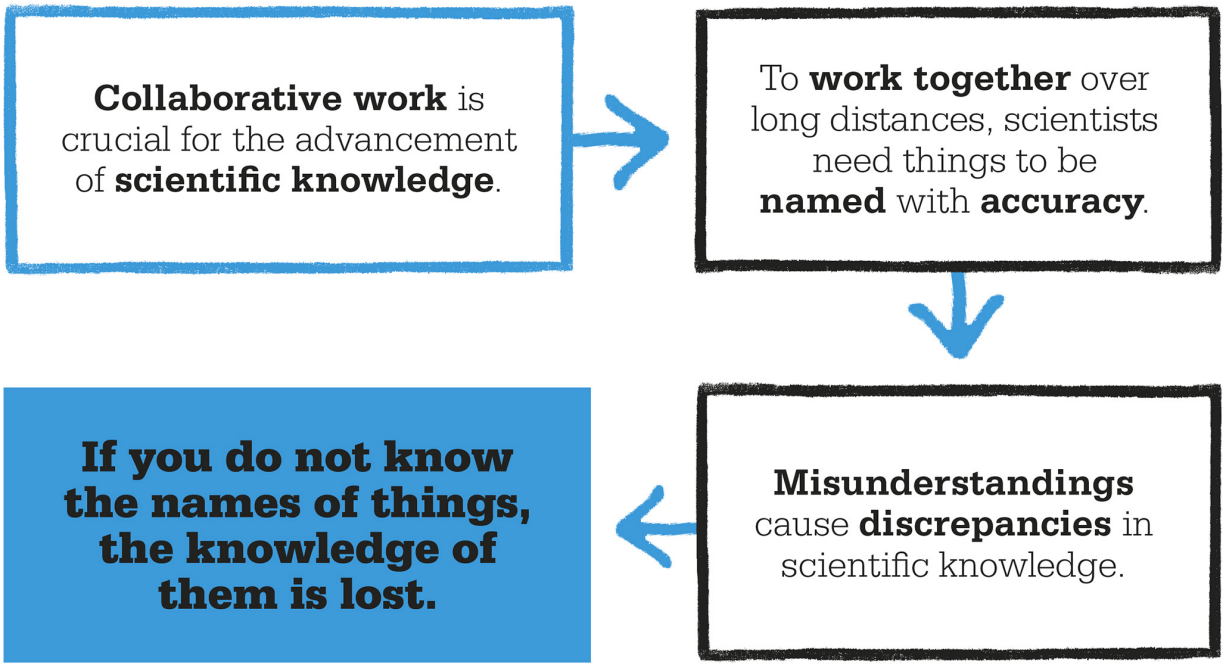
He is known as the “father of taxonomy”—the science of naming and classifying organisms.

Linnaeus divided both the plant and animal kingdoms into classes, orders, genera, and species. Organisms were placed in these levels on the basis of shared characteristics, such as similarity of body parts, size, shape, and methods of getting food. Linnaeus also adopted a precise two-word (binomial) name for each species.



Read accessible description

Early insights

By 1730, while still a student, Linnaeus began to have issues with the system for classifying plants developed by Joseph Pitton de Tournefort more than 30 years earlier. For Linnaeus, the characteristics of individual species needed to be analyzed more closely in order to produce a more thorough taxonomic system.

In 1732, he joined an expedition to Lapland, where he collected about 100 unidentified species. These formed the basis of his book *Flora*